

discipline and ideological cohesion under serious threat. The Right wound up in the flip-side of electoral history as did the Left. The combined electoral drubbing devalued its maximum leaders irreparably. L.K. Advani and Buddhadeb Bhattacharya are at the end of political days with the former handing over charge to a relatively unknown but brash successor, an innovative political gamble intended to end the infighting. Others to fall by the electoral wayside included Lalu Prasad, who was back to milking cows, a less onerous task than milking votes. The irony didn't end there. In the Indian political landscape, 2009 was a case of woman on top. The trio of Mayawati, Mamata Banerjee and Sonia dominated the political space and no one could ignore the paradox of a widow and two spinsters putting their male counterparts in the shade. Behenji, Didi and Madam had very little in common except expediency but they jointly rewrote the year's political box-office script.

Meanwhile, traditional scripts produced another colossal success story of the year, *Slumdog Millionaire*. Danny Boyle's compelling film on Mumbai's underbelly dominated international film awards, including the Oscars, where two slum kids stole the show and everyone's heart with their fantastical journey from Dharavi to the red carpet in

Los Angeles which, in comparative terms, eventually turned them into slumdog millionaires. Another Mumbai boy, Tendulkar was also honoured for his fantastical career by becoming the only Indian sportsperson to have his wax figure unveiled at Madame Tussauds in London while India's maximum city played host to another historic unveiling: the official

**THE REAL DEFINING MOMENT OF 2009 CAME IN THE GENERAL ELECTIONS WHEN 714 million Indians opted for stability in the face of a daunting price rise, the worst drought in decades and a global economic crisis.**

launch of the world's cheapest car, the Nano.

The Nano was a fitting enough debut in a year when austerity was selected as the UPA's primary slogan. Although better served by symbolism—five-star evictions and Kodak-moment cattle class seats for ministers—rather than adopted practice, austerity in officialdom was a desperately desirous goal. India's national debt, thanks to massive, unprecedented outlays in anti-poverty and social sector spend, had climbed to 78 per cent of its GDP, the highest ever. And, even though the situation bore little comparison to 18 years ago when Delhi had pawned 67 tonnes of gold to bail the country out of a balance of payments crisis, India, the world's biggest gold consumer, was prompted to buy 200 tonnes of gold from the International Monetary Fund for \$6.7 billion as a hedge against a nose-diving dollar.

Protection and prophylactics was, in a sense, the most visible symbol of 2009 as the swine flu pandemic sparked nation-wide panic and hospital masks became the most sought-after accessory of the year, except in the vast underdeveloped tribal belt, where it was the country-made pistol. If 2009 symbolised revival, so it was with the sharp rise and spread of the Maoists, who took their peasant uprising to a



**Jan 5** Omar Abdullah sworn in as the 11th chief minister of Jammu and Kashmir.



**Jan 20** Barack Obama sworn in as the 44th President of the USA.



**Jan 24** Prime Minister Manmohan Singh operated upon.



**Feb 1** Mahesh Bhupathi and Sania Mirza win Australian Grand Slam Mixed Doubles title.



**Feb 23** *Slumdog Millionaire* sweeps Academy Awards, wins eight Oscars.



**Feb 27** BSNL launches 3G mobile services in 11 cities.



**March 6** Mahatma Gandhi's belongings bought for \$1.8-million by Vijay Mallya.



**March 17** Varun Gandhi makes "anti-Muslim" speeches.



**March 19** Abdul Karim Telgi sentenced to 7 years' imprisonment.



**March 21** Mohanrao Bhagwat takes over as the RSS chief.



**April 28** Ottavio Quattrocchi dropped from the Red Corner Notice list of Interpol.



**May 28** UPA Government comes to power, 79 Cabinet ministers sworn in.



**June 3** Meira Kumar becomes the first woman Speaker of the Lok Sabha.



**June 11** WHO declares a swine flu pandemic—the first global flu epidemic in 41 years.



**June 15** Actor Shiney Ahuja arrested for raping his 18-year-old domestic help.



**June 25** Nandan Nilekani appointed chairperson of the Unique Identification Authority of India.